

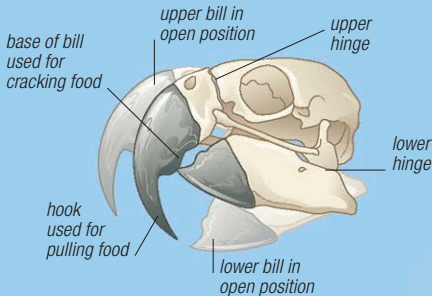
Parrots

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Psittaciformes
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	397

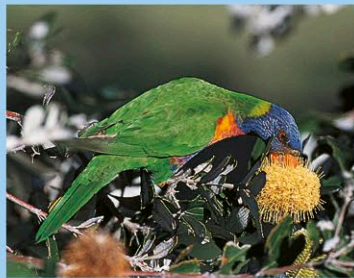
These conspicuous, brightly colored birds have populated most of the world's warmer areas, and are particularly abundant in tropical forests. In addition to true parrots, this group includes the familiar macaws, parakeets, cockatoos, cockatiels, lorikeets, and budgerigars, among others. Noisy and social in the wild, parrots have long been popular as pets, prized for their beauty, intelligence, and impressive learning skills, evident in their remarkable ability to mimic human sounds. Although they may range some distance to forage, very few parrots are truly migratory.

Anatomy

Parrots are easily recognized by their large head, short neck, and strongly hooked bill. They have hard, distinctively glossy plumage, usually predominantly green for camouflage in the forest foliage, with patches of other bright colors. Their feet, consisting of 2 toes pointing forward and 2 backward, are used for climbing trees, and the bill is frequently used as a third limb for climbing or holding. The wings are typically narrow and pointed, enabling parrots to fly with great speed and maneuverability.



PARROTS' BILL
A parrot's hooked bill is remarkably flexible; both the upper and lower mandibles are hinged against the skull for independent movement.



NECTAR FEEDERS
Lories and lorikeets (here, a rainbow lorikeet) feed on nectar. They have a brushlike tip to their tongue to help them sweep the liquid into their mouth.

Feeding

Virtually all parrots feed exclusively on plant material, including seeds, nuts, fruit, nectar, and flowers. Feeding is often an exercise in coordination between bill and foot, the latter grasping a food item and holding it up for the bill to work over. Although most parrots feed in the trees, many species also readily descend to the ground to forage.

SOCIAL GROUPS
Parrots (here, green-winged macaws and scarlet macaws) often form large, noisy flocks that communicate by making various calls, from harsh squawks to piercing shrieks. Most species form long-term pair-bonds.

CONSERVATION

Nearly a third of all parrot species are under threat in the wild, and a few have actually become extinct. One of the greatest threats is from the caged-bird trade, which accounts for hundreds of thousands of captures and deaths every year. Other threats to their numbers include deforestation.

Trichoglossus haematodus

Coconut lorikeet



Length 12 in (30 cm)
Weight 5 oz (150 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location New Guinea, S.E. Asia, S.W. Pacific, Australia (including Tasmania)



This brightly colored lorikeet has a stocky body and pointed tail. It is highly variable in appearance, with 22 subspecies that differ in size or coloration, or both. Juveniles have dark brown bills, while in adults they are orange or red. Like most other lorikeets and lories, this lorikeet has a brush-tipped tongue adapted for gathering pollen and nectar from flowers. In flight, the rainbow lorikeet screeches continuously while displaying

its brightly colored underwings. However, when feeding, its subdued chatter and cryptic coloration make it difficult to detect among foliage. This species causes damage in orchards and vineyards, especially in Australia.



FEEDING IN A GROUP



Flocks of rainbow lorikeets congregate to feed in flowering trees and are often found in the company of other nectar- or fruit-eating birds. This bird uses its bill to crush the flesh of fruit to extract the juice and the seeds. The rainbow lorikeet also feeds on insects and their larvae.

BRIGHTLY COLORED
This startlingly bright bird varies greatly in color. Most subspecies have green upperparts, a purple-blue streaked head, and an orange to red breast with dark scalloping.

Eos reticulata

Blue-streaked lory



Length 12¼ in (31 cm)
Weight 6 oz (175 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

Location Indonesia (Tanimbar, Kai, and Damar Islands)



This brightly colored lory is mainly red, with violet-blue streaking on its hind neck and back, a narrow, orange-red bill, and gray legs. A noisy, conspicuous bird, it is most commonly seen in swift overhead flight, emitting shrill call-notes, but also spends much time resting or feeding in trees. Like other lorikeets, it has a brush-tipped tongue to gather pollen and nectar.